

The Strategic Educator's 5-Minute Field Scan

A PLAYBOOK SAMPLE

A practical tool for the moments when the plan no longer matches the room. The goal is not to solve everything at once. It is to slow the leader down long enough to see the next responsible move.

1 NAME THE MISSION

What matters beyond completing the task?

2 RECORD THE EVIDENCE

What did I actually see, hear, read, or measure?

3 SEPARATE THE STORY

What meaning, motive, or label have I added?
What else might be true?

4 PROTECT WHAT MATTERS

What needs protection first: safety, dignity, trust, learning, or time?

5 WIDEN THE VIEW

Whose voice, context, expertise, or support may hold part of the picture?

6 CHOOSE AND WATCH

What is the smallest humane move? What signal will tell me to continue, stop, or change?

NEUTRAL EXAMPLE

Observed: Several students are talking, two have stopped working, and the instructions remain visible.

Story added: They are choosing not to care.

Other possibilities: The first step may be unclear, the task may feel too difficult, or the group may need a clearer time boundary.

Small move: Restate the purpose, model the first step, and check again after five focused minutes.

Signal: Are students beginning, asking more useful questions, or showing the same confusion?

Pause. Read. Choose. Watch.

Choose one lesson, conversation, team moment, or decision. Write what you know before writing what you think it means.

01 Mission

What matters beyond completing the immediate task?

02 Evidence

What did I actually observe, without assigning motive or identity?

03 Story and Possibilities

What story did I add? What else might be true? What evidence could prove my first reading incomplete?

04 Protection and Perspective

What needs protection first? Who else may hold part of the picture?

05 Move and Signal

What is the smallest humane move? What will tell me whether to continue, stop, or change?

ONE BOUNDARY

This scan is not a diagnostic tool and cannot replace safeguarding procedures, qualified judgment, institutional policy, or emergency action. When safety is at risk, follow the appropriate protocol.

The learner is never the enemy.

From The Warrior Teacher's Playbook by Matthew Pham